Safety in Shelters / Emergency Action Plan Job Tool

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools

Respond / Sheltering

Maintaining the safety of clients and workforce in shelters is an essential responsibility of all shelter workers. Each shelter should have an emergency plan and post an evacuation plan and maps showing assembly points outside the building. The evacuation plan and maps should be posted within 24 hours of opening. The *Shelter Emergency Action Plan* should be completed within 48 to 72 hours of opening. The plan should be emailed to the HQ Life Safety & Asset Protection (LSAP) Coordinator or HQ Logistics Manager when it is completed.

LSAP and/or Logistics/Facilities normally conduct basic safety inspections prior to opening a shelter, and LSAP conducts site visits in larger DROs to ensure continued safety and compliance with the *Shelter Emergency Action Plan*.

The Shelter Site Manager is responsible for emergency planning but may appoint a Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader to create the emergency plan, post an evacuation plan, and identify assembly points, monitor internal and external risks, and take steps to ensure safety. This task is delegated to a shelter worker in addition to their duties, rather than a individual being dedicated to the task.

External Risks

These risks from outside the shelter facility include heavy snow or water buildup on roofs, high winds and tornados, rising floodwaters, or approaching wildfires. These risks may endanger the facility and its clients and staff or may create conditions that isolate the shelter by cutting off roadways and communications. External risks may require immediate roof clearing, moving clients to a safer part of the facility, or evacuation to another facility.

Internal Risks

Risks inside the facility include wet floors, cracks or holes in floors that can cause falls and injuries, exposed electrical wire, damage to the facility that could cause injuries, and outbreaks of infectious diseases. The potential for fire, the absence of appropriate fire extinguishers, and blocked aisles and exits also create significant risks. While highly unlikely, there is also a possibility of an active shooter situation.

Action Items for Shelter Site Manager/ Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader

- ☐ Check that basic safety checks are occurring at the beginning of each shift as part of the shift inspection. That the *Shelter Shift Inspection Form* is kept in the *Shelter Log;*
- ☐ Mark and tape off any internal risks or hazards found and report them to the HQ LSAP Coordinator or HQ Logistics Manager to remedy. Follow up if necessary;
- ☐ Request a threat assessment from the HQ LSAP Coordinator and law enforcement in complex shelters;

- ☐ Identify disaster-related threats and monitor them to ensure changes do not threaten the safety of the shelter and its clients and staff;
- ☐ Prepare and maintain a *Shelter Emergency Action Plan*;
- ☐ Add shelter specific information to the attached *Shelter Emergency Action Plan;*
- ☐ Provide copies to the Shelter Site Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Dormitory Supervisor(s) and Shelter Registration Supervisor, and email to the HQ LSAP Coordinator or HQ Logistics Manager;
- ☐ Brief the Shelter Site Manager, Shift Supervisors, and staff from all shifts on the plan and actions they may need to take. Repeat this briefing weekly as a reminder and to account for staff turnover.



Shelter Emergency Action Plan

Name of Shelter *[_____]*

Street Location *[_____]*

DR # *[_____]*

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Purpose

This plan has been prepared by the Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader in preparation for potential significant threats to the shelter, its clients and its staff. Its purpose is to guide and coordinate actions required in the event of an emergency.

Plans for dealing with emergencies are listed below and are augmented for the specifics of the shelter facility. This document is based on American Red Cross Risk Management, Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), and National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) guidance for emergencies.

Emergency Evacuation for Fire, Gas Leak or Other Danger

The shelter may need to be evacuated for any number of reasons, including a gas leak and fire within the shelter.

The determination to make an emergency evacuation is made by the Shelter Site Manager or the Shift Supervisor in the absence of the Shelter Site Manager. Evacuation should be made as soon as alarms or visible signs of the threat exist.

Preparedness (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

As soon a feasible after shelter opening, the safety officer should determine evacuation routes and the assembly point outside the shelter, prepare and prominently post a drawing of the shelter indicating the evacuation routes and outside assembly point throughout the dormitory and shelter site. **The evacuation routes and assembly point drawing should be stapled to the back of this plan.**

In many cases and evacuation plan may already be prepared and posted in the shelter facility. If one exists, it should be used and minor adjustments to account for closed off areas of the shelter site and any additional assembly places required.

Evacuation Process (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

- ☐ Immediately dial 911 and report the emergency.
- ☐ Make a calm announcement telling residents them to leave personal belongings behind, and directing them to **walk not run** to the evacuation routes and assembly point.
- ☐ Shelter supervisors and workforce should be directed to disperse to specific locations to direct clients to the evacuation routes and assembly point. If heat is felt or smoke visible at an exit, direct clients to another route.
- ☐ Shelter workers should be assigned to assist clients with functional and access needs.

- ☐ A staff member should collect the client registration form book or folder and take it with them.
- ☐ The Shelter Site Manager or Supervisors should make a walk through the facility to ensure all residents and staff are evacuated.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator that the shelter has been evacuated.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Life Safety & Asset Protection (LSAP) Coordinator or HQ Logistics Manager that the shelter has been evacuated.
- ☐ Once at the evacuation point, clients should be calmed and made as comfortable as possible.
- ☐ A check of clients present against the registration forms and compile a list of missing individual compiled. Do the same for workforce and visitors using sign-in sheets.
- ☐ The Shelter Site Manager or the Shift Supervisor in the absence of the Shelter Site Manager should liaise with emergency personnel arriving to the scene until Life Safety & Asset Protection arrives and takes over that function.
- ☐ No one should be allowed to return to the shelter until emergency personnel and LSAP deem it safe.

Power Outage

Electrical power is important for lighting, refrigeration, heating/cooling equipment, medical devices, and computers and phones used in shelters.

Power outages regularly occur during disasters and can affect shelters with short- or longer-term power losses unless the shelter is served by backup generators.

Preparedness (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

Determine if the facility has a backup power generator and whether it switches on automatically or must be turned on and off manually and who should be contacted from the facility in the event of power outage.

Facility contact for this shelter is [_____]

Actions during Power Outages (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

- ☐ Only use flashlights and battery powered lanterns for emergency lighting. Do not use candles because they can cause fires.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator that power has been lost and ask them to inform the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager.
- ☐ Check on all clients with electrical medical devices to ensure they have battery power.

- ☐ Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed. Most food or medicine requiring refrigeration can be kept safely in a closed refrigerator for several hours. An unopened refrigerator will keep food cold for about 4 hours. A full freezer will keep the temperature for about 48 hours.
- ☐ Turn off or disconnect appliances and other equipment in case of a momentary power "surge" that can damage computers and other devices. Consider adding surge protectors.
- ☐ Monitor clients and workforce for cold or warm if the outage is prolonged and take necessary steps to improve comfort.

Tornados

Tornadoes can create significant loss of life and damage at a shelter so extreme care must be exercised in the event of tornado watches and warnings. Large areas used for shelters, such as gymnasiums, are vulnerable so clients may need to be moved within the facility for safety.

Preparedness (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

The safety officer should identify the safest location within the facility that clients and staff can be moved in the event of a tornado. Many facilities may already have designated spaces, but if they do not the best locations are normally windowless interior hallway in a basement, bathrooms or a hallway on the first floor if necessary.

The tornado safety location for this shelter is: [_____]

Tornado Watch (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

It is not necessary to move clients and staff to the safe area in the event of tornado watch. These indicate that weather conditions make tornados possible and that one should be prepared to act.

Whenever a tornado watch is issued for the area of the shelter, the safety officer or a designated person should monitor the battery-operated NOAA Weather Radio and local media for updates changes to a tornado warning.

Tornado Warning (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

A tornado warning indicates a tornado has been sighted physically or by electronic monitoring and that protective action should be taken immediately.

- ☐ Make a calm announcement telling residents to leave personal belongings behind, and directing them to **walk not run** to the predetermined safety location.
- ☐ Shelter supervisors and staff should be directed to disperse to specific locations to direct clients to the predetermined safety area.
- ☐ Shelter workers should be assigned to assist clients with functional and access needs.
- ☐ Make clients as comfortable as possible.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator that clients and staff are taking refuge in the predetermined safety area; Ask that the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager be informed.
- ☐ A staff member should collect the client registration form book or folder and take it with them.
- ☐ Check clients present against the registration forms and compile a list of missing individuals.
- ☐ The Shelter Site Manager or Supervisors should make a walk through the facility to ensure all residents and staff are out of the danger zones.
- ☐ No one should be allowed to return to other areas of the shelter until the tornado warning is lifted.

Severe Thunderstorm and Lightning

Strong winds and electrical storms can create significant damage and potential for loss of life in a shelter, particularly from falling trees and electrical shock.

Storm Warning (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

When a storm warning is issued, the Safety Office should monitor the situation using a battery-operated NOAA Weather Radio and local media for updates.

Storm Over Shelter (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

If the storm reaches the shelter, an announcement should be made telling clients and staff to:

- ☐ Avoid contact with corded phones and other devices including those plugged into electric for recharging. Cordless and wireless phones not connected to wall outlets are OK to use.
- ☐ Avoid contact with electrical equipment or cords. Unplug appliances and other electrical items such as computers and turn off air conditioners.
- ☐ Avoid contact with plumbing. Plumbing and bathroom fixtures can conduct electricity.
- ☐ Stay away from windows and doors, and inside.
- ☐ Do not lie on concrete floors or lean against concrete walls because shockwave can cause injury.
- ☐ Staff should move among the clients comforting and reassuring them.

- ☐ Make an announcement when the storm watch is lifted, and normal activity can resume.

Approaching Flood Waters or Wildfire

Approaching flood waters or wildfires should be carefully monitored and the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator immediately informed, and advice sought. Efforts will be made to move the shelter, clients and workforce.

If the threat is imminent and immediate evacuation is required, the shelter leadership should:

- ☐ Prepare to evacuate to the safest location possible in the area. This may not be designated assembly points.
- ☐ Ask on-site law enforcement, fire or emergency management officials for guidance.
- ☐ Determine the safest route to for clients and workforce to walk to safety.
- ☐ Make calm announcements organizing the clients. Move them out of the shelter and toward safety.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator you are evacuating the shelter; Ask that the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager be informed.
- ☐ Designate shelter workers to help anyone needing assistance.
- ☐ Registration workers should take the registration forms/books with them when they leave.
- ☐ Shelter Site Manager should take shelter logs and confidential records.
- ☐ A check of clients present against the registration forms should be made and a list of missing individuals compiled as soon as possible at the safe location.

Earthquake

Earthquakes, a sudden shaking caused by rocks shifting underneath the earth's surface, occur regularly without harming individuals or causing serious damage. Larger and sustained earthquakes have the potential to create significant damage and loss of life. They can damage structures and roads and cause fires, landslides, avalanches, and tsunamis. Aftershocks can be expected following a major earthquake and these can create additional damage.

The immediate dangers in shelters during earthquakes are from falling items or building collapse. Large open rooms such as shelter dormitories are vulnerable in strong earthquakes and little protection exists for individuals in them because there is little furniture under which to seek protection.

Preparedness (Action Required by Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader)

The primary preparedness task is to regularly check that that supplies, equipment and other materials are not stacked in a way that could fall on residents and staff during an earthquake and that the general evacuation plan is in place and posted throughout the shelter.

During an Earthquake (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

During a strong quake make an announcement if possible that residents and staff should drop to the ground and protect their heads and necks with their arms.

After an Earthquake (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

- ☐ Check clients and workforce for injuries and provide first aid if necessary. Call 911 for significant injuries.
- ☐ Check the shelter for damage. If it is damaged, evacuate the building and stay a safe distance from the structure and power lines.
- ☐ Contact the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator and report your situation; ask that the HQ Logistics Manager be informed.
- ☐ If you are in an area that may experience tsunamis, move clients and staff inland or to higher ground immediately.
- ☐ The Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader should monitor local news reports for emergency information and instructions via battery operated radio, TV, social media, or from cell phone text alerts.

Bomb Threat / Suspicious Package (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

In the event of a bomb threat against the facility, or concerns a suspicious package may be a bomb, take the following steps:

- ☐ Do NOT use two-way radios or cellular phones in the vicinity of a suspicious package; radio signals have the potential to detonate a bomb.
- ☐ Call 911 and report the bomb threat/suspicious package providing as much detail as you can.
- ☐ Follow law enforcement instructions.
- ☐ Do NOT approach or inspect suspicious items or unattended packages.
- ☐ Evacuate the area and seek protective cover from the bomb and potential debris.
- ☐ Contact the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator and report your situation; Ask that the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager be informed.

Hostile Intruder/Active Shooter (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

In the event of a hostile intruder or active shooter, the primary task of shelter workers is to protect residents in the shelter dormitory and themselves. Dial 911 immediately. inform them of a hostile intruder/active shooter situation. Be prepared to provide the following:

- ☐ Number and description of shooter(s).
- ☐ Location of the shooter(s).
- ☐ Type of weapon if known (e.g., handgun, rifle).
- ☐ Stay on the line to provide updates.
- ☐ Have another shelter worker contact the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator and report your situation as soon as possible; Ask that the HQ LSAP Coordinator and HQ Logistics Manager be informed.

Hostile Intruder/Active Shooter OUTSIDE the Facility (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Worker)

When hostile intruder/active shooter is outside the facility, the primary objective is to keep them from entering the shelter and from harming residents and staff from outside.

- ☐ Remain inside.
- ☐ The Shelter Site Manager or Shift Supervisor should order the immediate lockdown of the facility. Staff should close and lock all exterior windows and doors.
- ☐ Alert everyone inside the facility about the situation.
- ☐ Cover windows and try to get everyone down so that no one is visible from outside the facility.
- ☐ Call 9-1-1 and stay on the line with the dispatcher and provide your name; location and location of the incident; and number and identification of the shooters.
- ☐ Stay in place until the all-clear is given by law enforcement personnel.

Hostile Intruder/Active Shooter INSIDE the Facility (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Workforce)

If the hostile intruder or Active Shooter is inside the facility, the primary objective is to keep as many clients, staff, and visitor safe by helping them escape, restricting access to them, or attacking the hostile intruder/active shooter if there is no other option.

Assess the Situation. Determine the most reasonable way to protect your own life. Clients and visitors are most likely to follow the lead of Red Cross personnel during a hostile intruder/active shooter situation.

Determine the location of the shooter. TAKE IMMEDIATE ACTION in the method safest possible for you and clients.

Evacuate

If there is an accessible escape path, attempt to evacuate the premises.

- ☐ If the shooter is in the dormitory, staff should direct clients to flee through exits.
- ☐ Run away from the sound of shooting; put as much distance between you and the shooter as possible. Leave your belongings behind.
- ☐ Help others escape whenever possible.
- ☐ Call 9-1-1 when it is safe to do so.
- ☐ Warn others not to enter the area where the shooter may be.
- ☐ Do not attempt to move wounded people.
- ☐ Keep your hands visible.
- ☐ Follow the instructions of law enforcement.
- ☐ Go to the outside evacuation assembly point if safe. Do not leave the safe location or assembly point until instructed to do so by law enforcement.

Shelter in Place/Hide

If evacuation is not possible and the shooter is in other parts of the facility, staff members should close and barricade the dormitory door(s) with heavy furniture and items. In other parts of the facility, find a place to hide where the shooter is less likely to find you.

- ☐ Everyone should stay hidden and away from windows and exterior doors.
- ☐ Stay out of the shooter's view.
- ☐ Do not trap yourself or restrict your options from movement.
- ☐ Hide behind any large items (e.g., cabinets, desks).
- ☐ Silence your cell phone or pager.
- ☐ Remain quiet.
- ☐ Not come out until advised otherwise by law enforcement.

Attack the Hostile Intruder/Active Shooter

As a last resort and only when your life is in imminent danger, attempt to disrupt and/or incapacitate the shooter by:

- ☐ Acting as aggressively as possible to incapacitate him/her.
- ☐ Throwing items and using improvised weapons.
- ☐ Yelling and committing to your actions.

Infectious Disease Outbreak (Action Required by Shelter Site Manager and Shelter Emergency Readiness Leader and Disaster Health Services)

Infectious disease outbreak or threat will normally be brought to the attention of the shelter leadership by Disaster Health Services, a Public Health Agency or the HQ Sheltering

Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator. This may include infections such as influenza, Norovirus, or COVID-19.

- ☐ Ask for immediate guidance on how shelter operations should be altered.
- ☐ Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager/District Sheltering Coordinator if the information came from other parties.
- ☐ Contact the HQ Logistics/Facilities Coordinator if specialized cleaning is needed.
- ☐ Obtain specific job tools for the type of infection from The Exchange.
- ☐ Plan and institute protective measures advised by health authorities and job tools.
- ☐ Begin identifying and planning for an Isolation Care Area.

Evacuation Routes Drawing with Assembly Point(s) [Attach copy here]